

THE WHITE HOUSE
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MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telephone Conversation with Russian
President Boris Yeltsin

PARTICIPANTS: President Clinton
Russian President Yeltsin

Interpreter: Peter Afanasenko

Notetakers: Tony Campanella, Liz Rogers,
Robin Rickard, Joel Schrader, Chris Bell

DATE, TIME: October 5, 1998, 12:01 - 12:18 p.m. EDT,
AND PLACE: Oval Office

THE PRESIDENT: Hello, Boris? (U)

PRESIDENT YELTSIN: Hi, Bill. (U)

THE PRESIDENT: I am glad to hear from you. I understand you want to talk about Kosovo, and I do too. (C)

PRESIDENT YELTSIN: Yes. I have received your message on the subject of Kosovo, and of course, I share your concerns over the deteriorating situation and in connection with this, I wish to inform you of steps taken by the Russian side to ease tensions and promote a political settlement. I think you are having some problems with the telephone line, Bill? (C)

THE PRESIDENT: No, Boris. I hear you fine. (U)

PRESIDENT YELTSIN: I instructed my ministers including the Minister of Defense Sergeyev and Minister of Foreign Affairs Ivanov and also the First Deputy of Foreign Intelligence Service Shcherbakov to go urgently to Belgrade. They went last night and held discussions with Milosevic, and in very strong terms they insisted in a discussion with Yugoslavia's leadership on the need to take urgent steps to put an end to hostilities in

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Kosovo and to have troops withdraw and secret service units withdraw to their permanent location facilities and also to try and work for the process of negotiations. (S)

The talks held with Milosevic and Yugoslavia's Minister of Defense and Minister of Interior and people from the General Staff and from the special services of Yugoslavia demonstrated they heeded our appeal. Already they have taken some measures so that the situation may gradually return to some normalcy. And indeed, the situation in Kosovo is being gradually normalized. I know in the West not much trust is felt in what Milosevic is saying, and I don't have much trust or grounds for what he is saying either. But we still managed to get agreement from him to receive a mission from the OSCE, and he also delivered on another promise that the Government of Yugoslavia and the parliament support Russia's initiative and that they also welcome the OSCE mission coming to Yugoslavia. (S)

I believe that this is in large measure a breakthrough and we have to continue working so that we can really reinforce that breakthrough. Now, I already talked on this subject with the Secretary General of the United Nations, and the Secretary General heard from me that Yugoslavia has agreed to receive the Secretary General himself or his personal emissary. A group of Finnish experts is traveling there, I have discussed this with the President of Finland, and they will take part in investigating the murders and massacre of peaceful civilians that was committed there, and I have discussed this with the President of Finland. And we have lined up an impressive mechanism of international monitoring to pass judgement on this situation and to promote the normalization of this situation.

(S)

I wish to also underscore the fact that what concerns Belgrade equally concerns Albania and Kosovo. Security Council Resolution 1199 also applies to Albanians in Kosovo to give up the terrorist methods they are using. I am alarmed about aggressive talk of late about inevitable irreversible use of force by NATO in Yugoslavia. My position is known very well to all concerned. My position is that the situation cannot be resolved by use of force, and it is absolutely clear that a military gamble might have very grave consequences for the world at large and the Balkans, in particular, and this must not be allowed to happen. We are very firm on that. The international community has already accomplished a lot in strengthening peace and stability in the Balkans. If we look at the example of Bosnia and the subject of Kosovo, we should work with a view

toward accomplishing a political solution. Well, this is what I wanted to tell you on Kosovo. (S)

THE PRESIDENT: Thank you very much. First I want to thank you for your efforts. But let me -- (S)

PRESIDENT YELTSIN: (Interrupting) Thank you, Bill. (U)

THE PRESIDENT: Let me say what my concerns are. First I -- (S)

PRESIDENT YELTSIN: (Interrupting) Yes, and I think no one should be allowed to endanger the cooperation we have established. (S)

THE PRESIDENT: Let me say I am concerned that what Milosevic is doing is what he has done so often before in making false promises. He made a promise to you in June, which he didn't keep. Perhaps OSCE monitoring will help that. I want to say that we don't want to use force, and it is not inevitable. What happens next is entirely up to him. Our experience is that a credible threat of force is necessary to get him to comply so we don't have to use it. I think you may have gotten his attention, along with the pressure building up here. I am going to send Dick Holbrooke to Belgrade. Kofi Annan's report is a graphic account of Milosevic's continuing defiance of the international community. Many displaced persons are afraid to return home because they have no assurance of safety. He has suspended these operations and made his commitment to you now, but we simply have to know he is going to comply with UN requirements, and compliance has to be verifiable and irreversible. I do not want to use force, and force is not inevitable. If he thinks there is no threat of force, he never does anything. Your report is encouraging, and the OSCE may provide us a useful mechanism, but he has got to come through here, and his actions are what's important here and will determine what will happen next. (S)

PRESIDENT YELTSIN: Goodbye Bill. Thank you for this and goodbye. (S)

-- End of Conversation --